COLOSSIANS · STUDY 10 OF 12

# Colossians 3:18–4:1

## *The Relationships of the New Man*

**Christ Is All — A Study of Colossians**

Small Group Bible Study Series · NASB95

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| ① Text | ② Devotional | ③ Commentary | ④ Self-Study Guide |
|---|---|---|---|
| Foundation | Personal preparation | Teacher / leader preparation | Group meeting |
| *Everyone* | *All group members* | *Teacher / leader* | *Small group* |

⑤ *Application closes each study and draws from all sections above.*

Time guide: about 30 minutes — Devotional 4 · Commentary 15 · Discussion 8 · Application 3.

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## ① BIBLICAL TEXT

*Colossians 3:18–4:1 · New American Standard Bible (NASB95)*

**3:18** *Wives, be subject to your husbands, as is fitting in the Lord.*

**19** *Husbands, love your wives and do not be embittered against them.*

**20** *Children, be obedient to your parents in all things, for this is well-pleasing to the Lord.*

**21** *Fathers, do not exasperate your children, so that they will not lose heart.*

**22** *Slaves, in all things obey those who are your masters on earth, not with external service, as those who merely please men, but with sincerity of heart, fearing the Lord.*

**23** *Whatever you do, do your work heartily, as for the Lord rather than for men,*

**24** *knowing that from the Lord you will receive the reward of the inheritance. It is the Lord Christ whom you serve.*

**25** *For he who does wrong will receive the consequences of the wrong which he has done, and that without partiality.*

**4:1** *Masters, grant to your slaves justice and fairness, knowing that you too have a Master in heaven.*

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## ② DEVOTIONAL

*Personal preparation · Drawn from the outline of this study*

### Is There a Hitch in Your "Get Along"?

> *“Whatever you do, do your work heartily, as for the Lord rather than for men”*
> *— Colossians 3:23 (NASB95)*

It is one thing to sing hymns on Sunday. It is another to be gracious at the dinner table on Monday night or faithful at work on Tuesday morning when no one is watching. Paul takes the new self straight home and then straight to work.

Wives, husbands, children, fathers, servants, and masters each receive a word. None of these instructions is mere good advice, like the empty philosophies Paul has already exposed. They come with power, the indwelling Spirit; with purpose, the glory of God; and with a pattern, Jesus Christ. Moral philosophy without Christ is a train without an engine.

Notice how often the Lord appears in these verses: fitting in the Lord, well-pleasing to the Lord, fearing the Lord, as for the Lord, from the Lord, the Lord Christ, a Master in heaven. Every relationship is lived before Him. And He keeps the books. Faithful service, even in the humblest place, will receive the reward of the inheritance.

#### For reflection

1. In which of your relationships is it hardest to live as the new self?
2. Are you the same person at home that you are in public?
3. How would your work change this week if you did it "as for the Lord"?

*Every relationship is a place to serve the Lord Christ. He sees, and He rewards.*

# ③ COMMENTARY

*Teacher preparation resource · Full text organized under outline headings*

> **The passage teaches:** The new self lives out its new life in ordinary relationships: wives submit and husbands love without bitterness, children obey and fathers do not exasperate, servants work heartily as for the Lord and masters treat them justly, because each one serves the Lord Christ, who will reward faithfulness and judge wrong without partiality.

### Outline


**I. The Marriage Relationship (3:18–19)**
- A. Wives (3:18)
- B. Husbands (3:19)

**II. The Family Relationship (3:20–21)**
- A. Children (3:20)
- B. Fathers (3:21)

**III. The Business Relationship (3:22–4:1)**
- A. Servants (3:22–25)
- B. Masters (4:1)


## Introduction

Compare the parallel passages in Ephesians 5:22–6:9 and 1 Timothy 2. Is Paul simply offering good philosophical advice, like the false teachers? No! These instructions come with what no human philosophy can supply: **power**, the indwelling Holy Spirit; **purpose**, the glory of God; and a **pattern**, Jesus Christ. All moral philosophies without Christ are trains without engines.

The household codes of the ancient world were addressed almost entirely to the head of the house, and they spoke of his rights. Paul's code is different. He addresses each member directly, beginning with the one under authority, and he gives every person a responsibility before the Lord.

## I. The Marriage Relationship (3:18–19)

### A. Wives (3:18)

#### 1. What they are to do

"Wives, be subject to your husbands." The word (*hypotassō*) was a military term: to rank under, to arrange oneself in order. A wife recognizes her God-given rank in the family. Notice two things. First, it is to "your" husband (the NKJV reads "your own husbands"), not to all men. Second, the verb is middle or passive: it is something she chooses, not something he forces. God does not intend for a wife to yield to a husband who abuses her

or who orders her to do something contrary to God's will. "We must obey God rather than men" (Acts 5:29).

### 2. Why they are to do it

"As is fitting in the Lord." Submission rests on God's design, not on any inferiority of the wife in spirituality, intelligence, or worth. It is "fitting" because it is consistent with what God ordained in two areas:

**The order of creation.**

> *"Then the Lord God said, "It is not good for the man to be alone; I will make him a helper suitable for him.""*
>
> — Genesis 2:18 (NASB95)

> *"So the Lord God caused a deep sleep to fall upon the man, and he slept; then He took one of his ribs and closed up the flesh at that place."*
>
> — Genesis 2:21 (NASB95)

Matthew Henry put it memorably:

> *"The woman was made of a rib out of the side of Adam; not made out of his head to top him, not out of his feet to be trampled upon by him, but out of his side to be equal with him, under his arm to be protected, and near his heart to be beloved."*
>
> — Matthew Henry, Commentary on Genesis 2

Paul makes the same argument from creation order in 1 Timothy 2:13: "For it was Adam who was first created, and then Eve."

**The order within the Godhead.** Christ submits to the Father:

> *"But I want you to understand that Christ is the head of every man, and the man is the head of a woman, and God is the head of Christ."*
>
> — 1 Corinthians 11:3 (NASB95)

The Son is fully equal with the Father, yet He submits to the Father. It is obvious, then, that submission does not imply inferiority.

## B. Husbands (3:19)

### 1. Love your wives

"Husbands, love your wives." The word is *agapaō*, the self-giving love that seeks the good of its object. It is not *phileō*, a give-and-take affection, and certainly not *erōs*, a word that does not appear in the New Testament at all, the love that mainly takes. Ephesians 5 adds two patterns: love her as your own body, "for no one ever hated his own flesh" (Eph. 5:29), and love her "just as Christ also loved the church and gave Himself up for her" (Eph. 5:25). Loving here involves doing what is best for her, sacrificing self-interest for hers (John 15:13), and behaving unselfishly (1 Cor. 13:4–7).

### 2. Do not be embittered against them

"And do not be embittered against them." Do not nag, find fault, or be cross and harsh. Be the same in private as you are in public. Under both Jewish and Greek custom, nearly all the

privileges belonged to the husband and nearly all the duties to the wife. Here, for the first time, we see an ethic of mutual and reciprocal obligation.

## II. The Family Relationship (3:20–21)

### A. Children (3:20)

#### 1. What they are to do

"Children, be obedient to your parents in all things." "Children" (*tekna*) applies regardless of age or sex, though the context is children still under their parents' authority in the home. The word "obey" (*hypakouō*) literally means "to hear under," to listen and respond. Obedience should be prompt and willing, and it should be joined with honor (Eph. 6:1–3). Obedience without honor leads to frustration on both sides.

"In all things" has a limit: if a parent required a child to disobey God, the child should obey God rather than man (Acts 5:29; Eph. 6:1, "in the Lord"). And this command addresses minor children, not adults, especially married adults, who are to "leave … father and mother" and be joined to a spouse (Gen. 2:24). Adult children still honor their parents, but the chain of authority has changed.

#### 2. Why they are to do it

"For this is well-pleasing to the Lord." To wives Paul argued that submission is fitting, the right and proper thing, an appeal to reason and choice. To children he says that obeying parents pleases the Lord. Children want to please, and they can learn early that when they obey their parents, they please the Lord.

### B. Fathers (3:21)

#### 1. What they are to do

"Fathers, do not exasperate your children." The word (*erethizō*) means to stir up, provoke. It can be used in a good sense; its only other New Testament use is in 2 Corinthians 9:2, where the Corinthians' zeal "stirred up most of them." Here the context makes it negative. Some ways fathers, and parents, provoke their children are overprotection, favoritism, discouragement, failure to make allowances, and harshness or cruelty.

#### 2. Why they should not do it

"So that they will not lose heart." Some correction is necessary in discipline, but ceaseless irritation causes children to become discouraged, sullen, angry, and even hateful. Praise for well-doing rather than constant criticism, along with loving discipline (Heb. 12:7), helps rear children "in the discipline and instruction of the Lord" (Eph. 6:4). Remember: children are a gift from the Lord; they are to be dedicated to the Lord; they should know their parents are on their side; they need an example to follow; and they need creative, consistent discipline.

## III. The Business Relationship (3:22–4:1)

### A. Servants (3:22–25)

Wives, husbands, children, and fathers receive one verse each. Slaves receive four, and masters one. There may have been more slaves than masters in the church. Philemon, the master of the runaway Onesimus, belonged to this church (Philem. 1–2; Col. 4:9), and some slaves may have presumed on their fellowship with believing masters and not worked as hard as they should have.

Paul did not lead a campaign to abolish slavery, but he urged believers to behave as Christians within the social structures of their day, and he planted principles that would undermine slavery from within: the equal standing of slave and free in Christ (3:11), the accountability of masters to their own Master (4:1), and his appeal to receive Onesimus "no longer as a slave, but more than a slave, a beloved brother" (Philem. 16). He also told slaves to take their freedom if they could: "if you are able also to become free, rather do that" (1 Cor. 7:21). Today the principles of these verses apply most naturally to employees and employers.

#### 1. Obey your earthly masters (3:22)

"Slaves, in all things obey those who are your masters on earth." "On earth," literally "according to the flesh," marks them as earthly masters only. Only Christ is Master of a believer's spirit.

- **In all things:** not just the tasks you like. The Lord is first in your consideration; please Him first.
- **Not with external service:** literally "eye-service" (*ophthalmodoulia*), working only when the boss is watching, doing the bare minimum.
- **Not as those who merely please men** (*anthrōpareskoi*): performing for human applause.
- **But with sincerity of heart, fearing the Lord:** single-minded, undivided motives, because the Lord is watching even when the boss is not.

#### 2. Do your very best (3:23–24)

**You work for the Lord.** "Whatever you do, do your work heartily, as for the Lord rather than for men." "Heartily" is literally "from the soul" (*ek psychēs*). It is not merely external effort; it is wholehearted work. Your real Master is in heaven, and you work for Him. "What did my boss ever do for me?" Perhaps not much. "What has my Lord done for me?" Everything.

**He will reward you.** "Knowing that from the Lord you will receive the reward of the inheritance. It is the Lord Christ whom you serve." The word for "reward" (*antapodosis*) means a full recompense, a repayment in kind. Every believer receives an inheritance simply because he is a child of God (Gal. 3:18; Eph. 1:14, 18; 1 Pet. 1:4). But Scripture also speaks of an inheritance that is a reward, received as "wages" for faithful work. Joseph Dillow, in *The Reign of the Servant Kings*, develops this distinction at length: the faithful believer receives it; the unfaithful believer loses it, though he himself is saved (1 Cor. 3:14–

15). That is the inheritance in view here, and whether we receive it remains to be seen at the Judgment Seat of Christ. What a word to a slave who owned nothing on earth!

#### 3. Rest assured of God's justice (3:25)

"For he who does wrong will receive the consequences of the wrong which he has done, and that without partiality." A believer who ignores this message will not only lose reward but will also be repaid for the wrong he has done. Scripture does not tell us all that will entail, but God is perfectly just (2 Cor. 5:10). And "without partiality" cuts both ways: the slave cannot excuse his wrong because of his hard lot, and the master cannot escape because of his rank. Both stand before the same Judge.

### B. Masters (4:1)

#### 1. Treat your workers justly

"Masters, grant to your slaves justice and fairness." The word "fairness" (*isotēs*) is literally "equality." A master owed his slaves not only what the law required but what was equitable. James sums up God's attitude toward unjust employers:

> *“Behold, the pay of the laborers who mowed your fields, and which has been withheld by you, cries out against you; and the outcry of those who did the harvesting has reached the ears of the Lord of Sabaoth.”*
>
> — James 5:4 (NASB95)

#### 2. Remember your Master in heaven

"Knowing that you too have a Master in heaven." Every employer is himself an employee of the Lord. He is responsible to his Master and will give an account, in this life and in the next.

## Conclusion

Thomas Constable offers a helpful summary of how this passage fits the rest of Scripture: while all Christians stand on the same level in the Lord, there remain spheres in which God has ordained order and authority. In Christ there is neither Jew nor Greek, slave nor free, male nor female (Gal. 3:28). In the household, the husband is the head of the wife (Eph. 5:23), and children obey their parents. In the church, all are subject to Scripturally appointed leadership (1 Thess. 5:12; Heb. 13:17) and to the Lord. In the state, believers, though heavenly citizens, are subject to governing authorities (Rom. 13:1; Titus 3:1; 1 Pet. 2:13). In the workplace, employees serve their employers as unto the Lord.

Equality of worth and order of function are not enemies. Both come from the same Lord. Is there a hitch in your "get along"? Bring that relationship to the Lord Christ, whom you serve.

*Lord, thank You.*

# ④ SELF-STUDY GUIDE

*For use during the group meeting · Focused on the commentary text*

## Greek Word Study

*Grammar and parsing: Blue Letter Bible. Sources cited selectively: STR (Strong's), THAY (Thayer's), ATR (A. T. Robertson), VINE (Vine's), MRV (Vincent's), LXX (Septuagint usage).*

| Verse | Greek Word (Lexical Form) / English | Strong's # / Transliteration / Form | Definition & Significance |
|---|---|---|---|
| v.18 | **ὑποτάσσω**<br>*be subject* | **G5293**<br>*hypotassō*<br>Pres. Mid./Pass. Imp. 2nd Pl. | **THAY:** to arrange under, subordinate; a military term.<br>**ATR:** middle voice: a voluntary self-arrangement.<br>**Significance:** A wife's chosen recognition of God's order, not inferiority or coercion. |
| v.18 | **ἀνήκω**<br>*fitting* | **G433**<br>*anēkō*<br>Imperf. Act. Ind. 3rd Sg. | **STR:** to be proper, becoming.<br>**Significance:** Submission fits God's design in creation "in the Lord." |
| v.19 | **ἀγαπάω**<br>*love* | **G25**<br>*agapaō*<br>Pres. Act. Imp. 2nd Pl. | **VINE:** self-giving love that seeks the good of its object.<br>**Significance:** A husband's ongoing, sacrificial love modeled on Christ (Eph. 5:25). |
| v.19 | **πικραίνω**<br>*be embittered* | **G4087**<br>*pikrainō*<br>Pres. Pass. Imp. 2nd Pl. | **THAY:** to make bitter; passive, to become bitter or harsh.<br>**Significance:** No nagging, harshness, or resentment toward a wife. |
| v.20 | **ὑπακούω**<br>*be obedient* | **G5219**<br>*hypakouō*<br>Pres. Act. Imp. 2nd Pl. | **MRV:** literally "to hear under," to listen and respond.<br>**Significance:** Children listen and respond, pleasing the Lord. |
| v.20 | **εὐάρεστος**<br>*well-pleasing* | **G2101**<br>*euarestos*<br>Nom. Neut. Sg. | **STR:** fully agreeable, acceptable.<br>**Significance:** Obedience to parents pleases the Lord. |
| v.21 | **ἐρεθίζω**<br>*exasperate* | **G2042**<br>*erethizō*<br>Pres. Act. Imp. 2nd Pl. | **VINE:** to stir up, provoke; good sense in 2 Cor. 9:2, bad here.<br>**Significance:** Ceaseless irritation discourages children. |
| v.21 | **ἀθυμέω**<br>*lose heart* | **G120**<br>*athymeō*<br>Pres. Act. Subj. 3rd Pl. | **THAY:** to be disheartened, spiritless. Only here in the NT.<br>**Significance:** The result fathers must avoid: broken spirits. |
| v.22 | **ὀφθαλμοδουλία**<br>*external service* | **G3787**<br>*ophthalmodoulia*<br>Dat. Fem. Pl. | **MRV:** "eye-service," work done only under the master's eye.<br>**Significance:** Faithfulness does not depend on being watched. |
| v.23 | **ψυχή**<br>*heartily (from the soul)* | **G5590**<br>*psychē*<br>Gen. Fem. Sg. (*ek psychēs*) | **ATR:** "from the soul," with the whole inner self.<br>**Significance:** Wholehearted work as for the Lord. |

| Verse | Greek Word (Lexical Form) / English | Strong's # / Transliteration / Form | Definition & Significance |
|---|---|---|---|
| v.24 | **ἀνταπόδοσις**<br>*reward* | **G469**<br>*antapodosis*<br>Acc. Fem. Sg. | **THAY:** recompense, a full repayment. Only here in the NT.<br>**Significance:** The Lord repays faithful service in full. |
| v.24 | **κληρονομία**<br>*inheritance* | **G2817**<br>*klēronomia*<br>Gen. Fem. Sg. | **VINE:** an inheritance, property received; in places, a reward for faithfulness.<br>**Significance:** Here, the inheritance received as reward for faithful service (cf. Dillow). |
| v.25 | **προσωπολημψία**<br>*partiality* | **G4382**<br>*prosōpolēmpsia*<br>Nom. Fem. Sg. | **STR:** respect of persons, favoritism.<br>**Significance:** God judges slave and master by the same standard. |
| 4:1 | **ἰσότης**<br>*fairness* | **G2471**<br>*isotēs*<br>Acc. Fem. Sg. | **THAY:** equality, equity.<br>**Significance:** Masters owe what is equitable, not merely what is legal. |

**Grammar key** — Cases: Nom. · Gen. · Dat. · Acc. · Voc. | Number: Sg. · Pl. | Gender: Masc. · Fem. · Neut. Verb Mood: Ind. · Imp. · Subj. · Opt. · Inf. · Ptc. | Tense: Pres. · Imperf. · Fut. · Aor. · Perf. · Plpf. | Voice: Act. · Mid. · Pass. | Person: 1st/2nd/3rd Sg./Pl.

# Study Questions

## Part 1 — From the Commentary

| Review prompt | From the commentary |
|---|---|
| What three things make Paul's instructions more than moral philosophy? | Power (the Spirit), purpose (God's glory), pattern (Jesus Christ). |
| On what two orders does a wife's submission rest? | The order of creation (Gen. 2) and the order within the Godhead (1 Cor. 11:3). |
| What limits apply to obedience "in all things"? | No one must obey a command to sin (Acts 5:29); the command to children concerns minors at home. |
| Name some ways parents exasperate children. | Overprotection, favoritism, discouragement, failure to make allowances, harshness. |
| What is "the reward of the inheritance" (v.24)? | A reward for faithful service received at the Judgment Seat, distinct from the inheritance every believer has. |

## Part 2 — Study Questions

1. How does 1 Corinthians 11:3 show that submission does not mean inferiority?

> **Leader's answer:** Christ is fully equal with the Father, yet "God is the head of Christ." Submission concerns order and function, not worth. A wife can be fully equal in value and still choose to follow

God's order.

**2.** What does it mean for a husband not to be "embittered" against his wife, and why might Paul single this out?

**Leader's answer:** It means no harshness, nagging, or resentful attitudes. In a culture that gave husbands all the privileges, Paul introduces mutual obligation: authority is to be exercised in self-giving love, never harshly.

**3.** Why did Paul not command the abolition of slavery, and what principles did he plant that worked against it?

**Leader's answer:** He urged believers to live as Christians within their social setting, but taught the equality of slave and free in Christ (3:11), masters' accountability to their Master (4:1), and brotherhood that transforms the relationship (Philem. 16), and he encouraged slaves to gain freedom when possible (1 Cor. 7:21).

**4.** How should "as for the Lord" (v.23) change the way an employee approaches his work?

**Leader's answer:** He works wholeheartedly, not for eye-service or applause, because his real Master is Christ, who sees every task and will reward faithful service.

**5.** How does the study understand "the reward of the inheritance" and verse 25 from a Free Grace perspective?

**Leader's answer:** Every believer has an inheritance by grace, but there is also an inheritance-as-reward for faithful service (Dillow). Unfaithful believers lose that reward and will be repaid for wrong, but they are not lost (1 Cor. 3:15). God judges without partiality.

## Part 3 — Passage Summary

| Verses | Theme | Key truth |
|---|---|---|
| 3:18–19 | Marriage | Wives submit as fitting in the Lord; husbands love and are not embittered. |
| 3:20–21 | Family | Children obey, pleasing the Lord; fathers do not exasperate. |
| 3:22–25 | Servants | Work heartily as for the Lord; receive the reward of the inheritance; God judges without partiality. |
| 4:1 | Masters | Give justice and fairness; remember your Master in heaven. |

## ⑤ APPLICATION

*Closes the study · personal and corporate*

### 1. Be the Same at Home as in Public

**Scripture anchor:** Colossians 3:19

*Source: Draws from ③ Commentary, I.B.2, and ② Devotional*

The new self is tested most in the place where no one is performing. Husbands who are gracious at church and harsh at home have not yet brought their practice up to their position. The same is true of wives, parents, and children.

**Reflection:** Would your family describe you the way your church friends do?

**Practical step:** Ask your spouse or a family member, "What is one thing I could do to make home more peaceful?" and act on the answer.

### 2. Encourage, Don't Exasperate

**Scripture anchor:** Colossians 3:21; Ephesians 6:4

*Source: Draws from ③ Commentary, II.B; cf. Hendricks, Heaven Help the Home Today (FGR)*

Howard and Jeanne Hendricks taught a generation of families that discipline and encouragement belong together. Children who hear constant criticism lose heart. Children who are corrected lovingly and praised sincerely learn to trust the Lord their parents serve.

**Reflection:** Is the ratio of praise to criticism in your home healthy?

**Practical step:** Speak at least one specific word of praise to each child or grandchild in your life every day this week.

### 3. Work for an Audience of One

**Scripture anchor:** Colossians 3:23–24

*Source: Draws from ③ Commentary, III.A.2; cf. Dillow, The Reign of the Servant Kings (FGR)*

Faithful work in an ordinary job is service to the Lord Christ, and He will reward it. The reward of the inheritance is not earned salvation; it is the Lord's full recompense for faithful service by those who already have eternal life. No task is too small to be done as for Him.

**Reflection:** What part of your job do you do half-heartedly because no one notices?

**Practical step:** Choose one routine task this week and do it with excellence, consciously offering it to the Lord.

### 4. Lead as One Who Is Led

**Scripture anchor:** Colossians 4:1

*Source: Draws from ③ Commentary, III.B*

Anyone with authority over others, at work, in ministry, or at home, has a Master in heaven. Fairness, honesty, and generosity toward those under us are part of our accountability to Him.

**Reflection:** Is there someone under your authority who would say you are not fair?

**Practical step:** Review one decision affecting someone under your authority and ask, "Is this just and fair before my Master?"

*End of Study · Colossians 3:18–4:1*